

Mitsue Project

御杖村森林組合 (Mitsue-mura Forest Owners' Cooperative) Report

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"The forest our ancestors planted — the power that sustains the village they built" 先人が植えた森が、今、村を支える力になる。

1. Introduction

This report provides a comprehensive overview of the 御杖村森林組合 (Mitsue-mura Forest Owners' Cooperative), located in Mitsue Village, Nara Prefecture, Japan. The cooperative plays a crucial role in the sustainable management and development of the local forest resources.

2. Overview

Detail	Information	Source
Name	御杖村森林組合 (Mitsue-mura Forest Owners' Cooperative)	[2]
Location	1581 Sugano, Mitsue-mura, Uda-gun, Nara Prefecture, 633-1302, Japan	[2]
Established	January 1952	[2]
Capital	31,346,000 JPY	[2]
Business Area	Mitsue Village	[2]

3. Management and Staffing

The cooperative is led by a representative director. As of recent reports, the cooperative has a small but dedicated team:

Role	Number of Staff	Average Age	Source
Total Staff	4	30s	[2]
Field Workers	2	29	[2]
Office Staff	2	N/A	[2]

The cooperative emphasizes a young and energetic workforce, with an average age of 33 for permanent employees [2]. They focus on continuous training and skill development, especially in safety-critical operations like felling [2].

4. Main Operations

The Mitsue-mura Forest Owners' Cooperative's operations are primarily divided into three main departments [2]:

- Guidance Department (指導部門):** This department focuses on fostering future forestry successors, promoting stable supply of prefectural timber, issuing various certificates, facilitating timber transportation, conducting training sessions, disseminating information to members, providing consultation on forest maintenance and cultivation, and supporting forest education [2].
- Forest Maintenance Department (森林整備部門):** This department is responsible for forest maintenance projects, including surveying, felling, hauling, sales of forestry materials, and equipment repair [2]. In the previous two fiscal years, their activities included:
 - Two fiscal years prior: Thinning 68.3 ha, raw material production: 301 m³ of artificial forest [2].

- Previous fiscal year: Afforestation/thinning 65.98 ha, raw material production: 123 m³ of artificial forest [2].

- **Wood Processing Department (木材加工部門):** This department primarily handles the reception of raw timber logs for firewood, firewood production, timber transportation, and sales of wood products [2].

5. Budget and Financials

While a full financial statement for the cooperative was not directly accessible, the Mitsue Village 2025 General Account Budget provides insights into financial support and related forestry expenditures [1]:

Item	Amount (JPY)	Source
Subsidy to Village Forest Cooperative	2,000,000	[1]
Forestry Promotion Expenses	55,944,000	[1]
National Disbursements (Forestry Promotion)	3,564,000	[1]
Prefectural Disbursements (Forestry Promotion)	5,257,000	[1]
Forest Environment Transfer Tax	35,752,000	[1]
Forest Environment Maintenance Project	2,001,000	[1]
Abandoned Forest Maintenance Project	26,321,000	[1]
Forest Road Maintenance Expenses	1,600,000	[1]

These figures indicate significant investment from the village and higher-level governments into forestry activities within Mitsue Village, which likely benefits the cooperative's operations.

6. Forest Area and Membership

Mitsue Village has a total forest area of approximately 7,051 ha, with over 90% being privately owned forests. Coniferous trees, primarily杉 (Sugi - Japanese cedar) and 檜 (Hinoki - Japanese cypress), constitute the majority of the artificial forests, many of which were planted after World War II [3]. The cooperative's activities are centered around managing these forests within Mitsue Village [2].

Specific membership numbers for the cooperative were not readily available in the public documents reviewed, but it is understood that forest owners in the area are members, and the cooperative works on their behalf to manage forests and secure subsidies [4].

7. Welfare and Safety

The cooperative places a strong emphasis on employee welfare and safety. Benefits include family allowances, housing allowances, commuting allowances, business trip allowances, provision of uniforms and safety equipment, annual medical check-ups, social gatherings, company trips, training trips, and long-service awards. They also provide congratulatory payments for marriage and childbirth, along with related leave [2].

Safety is a top priority, with an 8-year consecutive record of zero labor accidents. They implement a unique training program for new employees covering field work, office tasks, and customer service. Regular training sessions focus

on job content and improving safety awareness. Felling operations, being high-risk, are never assigned to individuals without sufficient experience and knowledge, even after obtaining qualifications. Daily "Hiyari Hatto" (near-miss) reports are shared to continuously enhance safety awareness and knowledge [2].

8. References

[1] Mitsue Village 2025 General Account Budget (令和7年度御杖村一般会計予算) - <https://www.vill.mitsue.nara.jp/material/files/group/3/R7yosan-ippan.pdf> [2] 御杖村森林組合 (Mitsue-mura Forest Owners' Cooperative) - Rinroad - <https://rinroad.com/company/p18539/> [3] Nara Prefecture Mitsue Village | National Research and Development Agency Forestry and Forest Products Research Institute (奈良県御杖村 | 国立研究開発法人 森林研究・整備機構) - https://www.green.go.jp/suigenrin_jigyo/jirei50sen/jirei50_30/ [4] A forest owners' cooperative in Japan: obtaining benefits of ... - FAO - <https://www.fao.org/4/a1346e/a1346e17.pdf>